

LIVE

Learning Space

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ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

6th WEEK



CRISIS IN MALDIVES

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... INDIA AND ITS NEIGHBOURHOOD-RELATIONS, EFFECT OF POLICIES AND POLITICS OF DEVELOPED AND DEVELOPING COUNTRIES ON INDIA'S INTERESTS.

2

Crisis in Male

Fresh elections, with the opposition free to contest, are the best option for the Maldives.

Matters are coming to a head in the Maldives, with President Abdulla Yameen's government pitted against the judiciary, polity and sections of the bureaucracy. Mr. Yameen has ruled since 2013 when he won power in an election, the result of which is still contested. He defeated Mohammad Nasheed, who had been deposed in 2012 and who, in 2015, was sentenced to 13 years in prison on charges of terrorism. Mr. Nasheed is now in exile. In an order on February 1, the Supreme Court cancelled his imprisonment term and that of eight other political leaders, reinstated 12 parliamentarians who had been disqualified last year, and ordered Mr. Yameen to allow the Maldivian parliament, or Majlis, to convene. Mr. Yameen has thus far failed to comply with any of these orders, despite an official statement on February 2 about his government's "commitment to uphold and abide by the ruling of the Supreme Court". The most egregious failure is the government's refusal to cancel the imprisonment of the nine leaders, amongst whom is Mr. Yameen's former vice president and his former defence minister, members of parliament and leaders of major opposition parties, apart from Mr. Nasheed himself. The President has also refused to allow the Majlis to meet, which has led to the resignation of its Secretary General. In fact, the government sent in the army to stop lawmakers from entering the premises, besides arresting two parliamentarians at the airport. Meanwhile, several officials, including two police chiefs and the prison chief have resigned or been sacked, reportedly for seeking to implement the Supreme Court's orders. The Attorney General has now announced that only the Constitution matters, not "illegal orders" from the court. In short, the Maldives is in the midst of a constitutional crisis. Calling fresh elections, which are in any case due later this year, may be the best way out.

Amidst the turmoil, India has joined the U.S., the European Union and several other countries in calling for Mr. Yameen to carry out the Supreme Court's order. New Delhi said in a statement that it is monitoring the situation in Male "closely". But currently, Delhi's leverage in the Maldives is less than it has ever been. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's decision to cancel his visit to Male three years ago, has singled Maldives out as the only country in the South Asian and Indian Ocean Region that he hasn't visited. Given that the Maldives has pulled out of the Commonwealth, and there is little semblance of a SAARC process at present, India's influence in Male is further limited. It will require concerted action from the international community to persuade Mr. Yameen to steer the Maldives out of this crisis, without taking recourse to coercive means.

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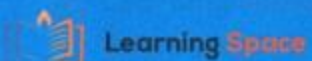
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UPSC CSE – GS II

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MALDIVES ... FACTUAL INFORMATION

Abdulla Yameen
Maldivian President

- Country located in the Indian Ocean
- Capital is Male
- Located towards South of India
- Consists of 1192 coral islands in a double Chain of 26 atolls
- Religion is Islam

- Known for luxury tourism
- Became independent in 1965
- Area is 298 sq.km
- Population .. 4,00,000 (approx.)
- Currency ... Maldivian Rufiyaa
- Unitary Presidential constitutional Republic

MALDIVES ... FACTUAL INFORMATION

CORAL ISLANDS

- Coral island is a type of island formed from coral detritus and associated organic material.
- They occur in tropical and sub-tropical areas, typically as part of coral reefs.
- Coral reefs are diverse underwater ecosystems held together by calcium carbonate structures secreted by corals.

ATOLLS

- An atoll, sometimes called a Coral atoll, is a ring-shaped coral reef including a coral rim that encircles a lagoon partially or completely.



MORE ABOUT MALDIVES

**Maumoon Abdul Gayoom**

President,
1978 - 2008

**Mohamed Nasheed**

President, 2008-2012
(He was convicted under anti-terror law
and sentenced to 13 years in prison and he
is at present in exile)

**Abdulla Yameen**

President (since 2013 ...),
who is accused of stifling
human rights

- *Tourism is the mainstay of Maldives economy and it is suffering badly because of political instability.*
- *India is treading cautiously.*



ABDULLA YAMEEN
PRESIDENT, MALDIVES



WHAT IS THE RECENT ORDER OF THE SUPREME COURT?

- 1** The Supreme Court cancelled his imprisonment term and that of eight other political leaders, reinstated 12 parliamentarians, who had been disqualified last year.
- 2** The Supreme Court also ordered Mr. Yameen to allow the Maldivian Parliament, Majlis to convene.
- 3** Mr. Yameen failed to comply with any of these orders, despite an official statement about his Government's commitment to uphold and abide by the ruling of the Supreme Court, initially.

WHAT IS THE GOVERNMENT'S REACTION?



ABDULLA YAMEEN
PRESIDENT,
MALDIVES



MOHAMED NASHEED
FORMER PRESIDENT,
MALDIVES



Meanwhile, Maldives is shifting towards China and tourism paradise is badly affected in the nation of 3,40,000 Sunni Muslims.

- 1** The Government refused to cancel the imprisonment of nine leaders, among them are former Vice-President and the former Defense Minister, MPs and leaders of major Opposition Parties, along with Mr. Nasheed.
- 2** The President has also refused to allow the Majlis to meet, which has led to the resignation of the Secretary General.
- 3** Now, there are news reports that the Abdulla Yameen Government is going to sack the Supreme Court Judges.
- 4** The Attorney General announced that only the Constitution matters, not illegal orders from the Court.

NOW, STATE OF EMERGENCY



- 1** Now, Maldives Government declared a State of Emergency for 15 days.
- 2** The President Office said, during this time, though certain rights will be restricted, general movements, services and businesses will not be affected.
- 3** This development comes 5 days after the Supreme Court ordered the immediate release of 9 Opposition Leaders.
- 4** The Court also ordered that 12 MPs, expelled earlier, be reinstated.
- 5** Emergency rule gives security officials extra powers to arrest dissidents.



ABDULLA YAMEEN
PRESIDENT, MALDIVES



WHAT IS INDIA'S RESPONSE?

- 1** India joined the U.S., European Union and other countries in calling for Mr. Yameen to carry out the Supreme Court's order.
- 2** New Delhi said in a statement that it is monitoring the situation in Male closely.
- 3** In fact, Narendra Modi cancelled his visit to Male three years ago.
- 4** Moreover, Maldives pulled out of Commonwealth previously and there is not much action under SAARC.

India's influence in Male is further limited.



Arabian Sea

INDIA

Bay of Bengal

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CAM

Gulf of Thailand

SRI LANKA

SOMALIA

YEMEN

MADAGASCAR

Indian Ocean

MALE
MALDIVES



ABDULLA YAMEEN
PRESIDENT, MALDIVES



*Now, it is the
responsibility of the
International Community
to persuade Mr. Yameen
to steer the Maldives out
of this crisis.*